

TUTORING SUPPORT AS A RESPONSE TO THE CHALLENGES OF OVERCOMING LEARNING LOSSES UNDER THE CONDITIONS OF WAR IN UKRAINE**Shvets T.**

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Abstract

The article addresses the issue of overcoming learning losses among students in secondary educational institutions in Ukraine. The author analyzes the causes of learning losses, possibilities for overcoming them, and emphasizes the importance of supporting students, especially their psychosocial well-being, which affects academic success. The article suggests steps to overcome learning losses through the application of tutoring as a method of individualization in education. It is noted that in order to provide tutoring support, teachers must possess certain competencies. Additionally, the author identifies the advantages of tutoring support that influence the outcomes of overcoming learning losses.

Keywords: tutor, tutoring support, learning losses, tutoring competencies.

With the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic, the fundamental human right - the right to education - came under threat, as correctly noted by H. Bychko and V. Tereshchenko [1]. In the spring of 2020, educational institutions were closed in most countries, effectively halting the educational process for a period of time. Gradually, educational systems in countries adapted to the new conditions by introducing distance and blended learning. However, leading experts from international organizations still speak of learning loss as one of the biggest problems, as its consequences will manifest over time, thus affecting the quality of life of individuals and the development of societies as a whole [1, p. 3]. Research by the Organization for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) [4] indicates that students who stopped attending school due to the pandemic-related closures may have a lower income throughout their lives by approximately 3%. In turn, this could lead to an average annual GDP decline of 1.5% by the end of the century. Therefore, it is crucial to direct efforts towards compensating for learning losses. H. Bychko and V. Tereshchenko, analyzing the terminological series of the concept of «learning losses», proposed the following definition: learning losses are «any loss of knowledge, skills, abilities, and/or a slowdown or interruption of academic progress due to breaks in the education of a specific student. These losses occur as a result of prolonged absences from classes (for example, due to health problems), ineffective teaching, significant unplanned interruptions in education associated with social crises, wars, natural disasters, etc.» [1, p. 8].

In Ukraine, learning losses are associated not only with quarantine restrictions but also with the full-scale war. The war has caused a series of negative life events: loss of loved ones, displacement, lack of educational infrastructure, and radical changes in everyday life [6, p. 275]. According to the information report of the Ministry of Education and Science of Ukraine [2], prior to the invasion of the Russian Federation into Ukraine,

there were 13,991 general secondary education institutions (GSEIs) of various types and forms of ownership, where 4.23 million students received education. According to the Ministry of Education and Science, as of the end of the 2022/2023 academic year, there were 12,930 GSEIs functioning, where approximately 4.04 million students were receiving education through various forms of learning. Since the beginning of the war with Russia against Ukraine, GSEIs have suffered destruction and damage, with some of them ending up in temporarily occupied territories. According to the operational data of the Ministry of Education and Science, as of July 20, 2023, 190 GSEIs (including special and specialized institutions) were destroyed, and 1,619 GSEIs were damaged. In temporarily occupied territories, together with their branches, there were 894 GSEIs (as of May 21, 2023) [7]. Most of the destruction of GSEIs was recorded in Donetsk, Kharkiv, and Kherson regions, while damages were reported in Dnipropetrovsk, Donetsk, Zaporizhzhia, Kyiv, Luhansk, Mykolaiv, Kharkiv, and Kherson regions. Unfortunately, this figure is constantly increasing. Even in relatively safe regions, education in face-to-face or blended formats is constantly disrupted due to air raids, power outages, and so on. According to the analytical report of the State Education Quality Service of Ukraine «Study of the Quality of Organization of the Educational Process in the Conditions of War in 2022/2023», according to the estimates of teachers, about 30% of students do not have regular access to the educational process in conditions of war, with the highest percentage in the South being 40%. Considering the type of settlement, more students have access to education in cities, and fewer in villages. These differences are especially pronounced among students from socially vulnerable categories: in cities, 68% of teachers believe that all students from low-income families have access to education, while in villages, it's 54%; for students from large families, it's 76% and 64%, respectively, and for students with disabilities, it's 86% and 80%, respectively.

War in Ukraine has not only complicated students' access to education but also significantly affected its quality. Experts identify a range of problems that negatively impact the learning outcomes of Ukrainian children [1, p.14]:

- Residing in temporarily occupied territories;
- Living in active combat zones;
- Change of residence;
- Destruction of educational institutions;
- Air raids;
- Power outages.

However, this list should also include issues related to the psychoemotional state of students. Children can only learn well when they feel well, however, with the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic and later full-scale war, the mental health of children has deteriorated significantly. Compared to early February 2022, the number of students feeling anxious, tense, and tired almost doubled, while the number of those feeling safe, calm, energetic, and happy decreased by 20% [7].

In the conditions of a state of war, intensive search for new approaches to learning, innovative forms of organizing the educational process, and effective pedagogical methods are taking place. Research [7] indicates a decrease in the number of students possessing skills necessary for independent learning: time management, organizing their work, completing tasks independently, and self-assessment. Therefore, compensating for learning losses through self-study of educational materials may be ineffective for some students.

Experts, including those from the OECD, World Bank, and UNESCO, in their publications have analyzed various strategies that can contribute to reducing or overcoming learning losses due to school closures during the COVID-19 pandemic. According to the Global Education Coalition of UNESCO [7], one in five countries provided students with additional time to master the school curriculum, meaning there was an increase in the number of hours devoted to studying the material. Strategies for increasing study hours can vary: summer schools, studying during vacations, double lessons, and Saturday schooling. However, such decisions also have their drawbacks, as children need rest for quality learning. The most convincing results were obtained by schools in the United States that organized tutoring in small groups (2–6 students).

A. Schleicher, the Director for Education at the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, who studied the educational situation in countries affected by natural disasters and wars and analyzed the consequences of the pandemic for the education community over two years, identified the following steps to overcome learning losses [8]:

- Adaptation of the educational environment to the challenges resulting in learning losses;
- Increasing study time;
- Providing flexibility in the curriculum;
- Flexible teaching strategies;
- Adapting teaching strategies to individual students' needs (especially those with traumatic experiences).

A. Schleicher also emphasized the emotional support of students with traumatic experiences. The expert referred to the experience of Colombia, where educational cycles involving internally displaced children

due to civil war or emergencies were introduced. Children studied in small groups, received personal attention, and were provided with social-emotional support. In the United Kingdom, a national mentoring program has been implemented. In addition to online learning and tutoring services, mentors also provided students with psychosocial and emotional support. A similar system was in place in Spain.

To implement tutoring support, it is necessary to thoroughly analyze the competencies of tutors in the conditions of war. The author believes the most effective educational strategy for determining tutoring competencies in these circumstances is scaffolding. The strategy was first presented in 1976 by D. Wood, J. Bruner, and G. Ross in the work «Role of Tutoring in Problem Solving» [9]. In this strategy, the tutor understands the individual characteristics of students, selects appropriate tasks, monitors students' reactions (prevents fear, stress, etc.), directs the student's actions, closely observes their progress, and provides support in both academic and non-academic activities. Gradually, the degree of such support decreases, giving way to the student's independence. The scaffolding strategy resembles Lev Vygotsky's theory of the «zone of proximal development» [5]. It is worth noting that Vygotsky's theory helps us define the role of the tutor - assisting the student in their zone of proximal development, providing support, and gradually guiding them towards independence. The essence of scaffolding lies precisely in temporary support for the student.

Therefore, important competencies of a tutor for guiding students in wartime conditions include:

- Possession of specialized knowledge in psychology considering the peculiarities of wartime: how to support oneself as an educator;
- Proficiency in information managing methods; the ability to find necessary information, systematize and generalize it; the ability for critical analysis of information; applying knowledge and media literacy;
- Mastery of planning and managing tutoring activities, knowledge of creative adaptation techniques to the content and structure of tutoring activities, enhancing individual potential and creative abilities of students;
- Ability to organize tutoring processes, various types and forms of tutoring activities; creating space for the development of tutoring practice;
- Understanding of students' psycho-emotional states;
- Ability to forecast the development of students' personalities and predict the pedagogical process;
- Tutor's ability to compensate for factors hindering learning;
- Effective communication skills, including a positive attitude towards others, openness, ability to construct one's own speech communication, establish contact, formulate points of view, listen and evaluate statements, control the course of communication, draw conclusions, and summarize discussions, ability to build a communication strategy;
- Ability of the educator to provide favorable conditions for each student considering their individual needs, abilities, opportunities, and interests; ability to provide support to students considering their individual characteristics;

- Knowledge and use of elements of self-therapy (physical exercises, breathing exercises, art activities), reducing students' anxiety. It is important for the tutor to be able to talk to students not only about the war but also about the future.

Nowadays, after the pandemic and as a result of the military actions in Ukraine, compensatory competence becomes increasingly relevant. Teachers who possess it can help students returning to Ukraine from abroad, where they studied in integrative classes, or children who interrupted their education due to occupation. A tutor with compensatory competence can develop strategies for individual support for such students, plan compensatory measures for students in wartime conditions: individual and group consultations, providing students with additional socio-emotional support, which will contribute to stabilizing students' emotional state, preventing loss of motivation for learning and development. Also, the author believes that compensatory competence includes not only the ability to help students but also the ability to help teachers themselves. This includes compensating for one's own general pedagogical and professional skills, the ability for self-help in stressful situations, skills and abilities to support psychological well-being and balance one's own life resources.

Considering that a large number of children in Ukraine are studying remotely, tutor support becomes increasingly important for successful learning. Tutors can assist students in various aspects of learning: self-learning skills, maintaining motivation for learning, and promoting psychosocial stability. The advantages of tutor support include:

1. Individual approach based on understanding students' needs, emotions, and interests to provide necessary support tailored to their individual characteristics. Overcoming learning losses involves creating individual learning plans for students based on their unique needs, strengths, and learning styles. These plans may include individual tasks, assessments, and learning materials developed according to specific student needs. Individualized learning can help students feel more engaged and motivated to learn, as well as promote self-confidence.

2. Online tutoring allows students to stay connected with tutors regardless of their location or time zone. As mentioned, online student support can be both academic—related to learning (help in developing general self-learning skills, tracking progress in learning, overcoming learning obstacles, etc.) and non-academic—helping students with emotional and psychosocial aspects (practical assistance in increasing motivation for learning, self-regulation, self-assessment, etc.).

3. Development of soft skills. Tutor support can contribute to the development of various skills in students, from logical thinking to working with different educational resources, from organizing their learning to coping with life challenges. Such collaboration allows students to maximize their potential.

4. Collaborative learning involves students working on group projects. This fosters a sense of commu-

nity among students, meets their need for communication and collaboration. Collaborative learning can be organized in both distance and blended formats.

5. Gamification or the use of mobile apps. Tutors can recommend students to use mobile apps to help them learn more effectively and organize their time. Gamification also involves incorporating game elements (badges, points), giving students a sense of achievement, and motivating them, etc.

In summary, it can be argued that the mentioned challenges of supporting students in wartime conditions can be addressed by implementing tutor support for students. All Ukrainian children currently need special support, and professional school tutors can become such unique assistants, as they have accumulated experience in remotely supporting students in an online format during the COVID-19 pandemic. Also, in wartime conditions, creating a safe educational environment and organizing the educational process for all students, especially those with traumatic experiences, becomes crucial.

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